

Extent Of Atonement

doc-extent-of-atonement

Soteriology · Atonement · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

The atonement is sufficient for all but applied/efficient for the elect (or, in some traditions, genuinely universal in provision); Brethren tradition typically holds general atonement, with sincere universal gospel offer.

In plain language

The question asks how wide the Bible says Jesus' death reaches. The Greek words in the cited verses point in two directions at once, and that is the heart of the dispute. Some verses use broad words. John 3:16 says God loved the world (kosmos), and 1 John 2:2 says Christ is the propitiation, that is the sacrifice that turns away wrath (hilasmos), not for our sins only but for the whole world (holou tou kosmou). First Timothy 2:6 calls him a ransom for all (antilytron hyper panton), and Hebrews 2:9 says he tasted death for everyone (hyper pantos). Other verses use narrow words. In John 10:11 and 10:15 the good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep (hyper ton probaton), naming a specific flock. The trouble is that the words themselves do not settle the matter, and the data shows exactly why. The word for all (pas) is used both ways across the canon: it can mean every single person, and it can mean all kinds or all classes of people. The word world (kosmos) appears in the texts with several different senses, from the created order, to humanity in general, to the world set against God, so it does not by itself pin down a number. Most striking, the little word translated for or on behalf of (hyper) is the very same grammar in for the sheep and in for all. Its job is to say who benefits, not to draw a fence around them, so saying a death is for the sheep does not by grammar say it is for no one but the sheep, and within the same chapter Jesus adds that he has other sheep not of this fold. So readers who start with the broad words conclude the death is offered for everyone, and readers who start with the narrow words conclude it is aimed at a defined group, and each can defend the reading from the same vocabulary. The neat phrase sufficient for all but applied for some is one way to hold both kinds of verse together, but no word in these texts carries that distinction. On the words alone, the extent of the atonement stays an open and genuinely disputed question.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	
G0487	ἀντίλυτρον	antilytron	ransom	1
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	37
G1089	γεύομαι	geuomai	to taste	15
G2434	ἱλασμός	hilasmos	propitiation	2
G2889	κόσμος	kosmos	world	185
G3650	ὅλος	holos	all	108

G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,244
G4166	ποιμήν	poimen	shepherd	18
G4263	πρόβατον	probaton	sheep	39
G5087	τίθημι	tithemi	to place	100
G5228	ὑπέρ	hyper	above/for	150

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The canon supplies two scope patterns that the words themselves do not rank. Universal-sounding language appears in John 3:16 ("the world", ton kosmon), 1 John 2:2 ("the whole world", holou tou kosmou), 1 Timothy 2:6 ("a ransom for all", antilytron hyper panton), 2 Peter 3:9 ("all", pantas), and Hebrews 2:9 ("for everyone", hyper pantos). Particular-sounding language appears in John 10:11 and 10:15 ("life for the sheep", ten psychen hyper ton probaton). The decisive fact is that "for" or "on behalf of" (hyper) plus a noun in the "from-X" grammatical form (a genitive object) is the SAME benefactive construction (a grammar pattern that names who benefits, classified in Louw-Nida domain 90.36, the standard semantic dictionary's category for "on behalf of") in both sets. It names whom the death benefits, not whom it excludes, so "for the sheep" does not by grammar mean "for the sheep only". Compounding this, "world" (kosmos) is genuinely polysemous (carries multiple senses) across at least four attested senses in the queried data (the created order, mankind, the world-system in opposition to God), and "all" (pas) carries both a collective totality sense and a distributive "each" sense. Two careful readings of the identical word-forms (lemmas) reach opposite scopes, so the pattern is materially contested rather than decisive.

Scripture

John.3.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2889 κόσμος, G0025 ἀγαπάω

Reasoning. God loved "the world" (ton kosmon), which is in the accusative (the direct-object grammatical form), the direct object of "he loved" (egapesen), and gave the only Son "so that everyone who believes" (hina pas ho pisteuon), so that the believing one may not perish but have eternal life. The object of the giving is "world" (kosmos), the broad designation, but the clause that names who receives life is restricted by the substantival participle (a participle acting as a noun) "everyone who believes" (pas ho pisteuon), "the believing one". So the verse pairs a wide-scope object of love with a faith-conditioned scope of life. Read one way it is universal provision, read the other way it is effectual provision toward those who believe, and the vocabulary supports both.

1John.2.2 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2434 ἱλασμός, G3650 ὅλος, G2889 κόσμος

Reasoning. Christ is the "propitiation" (hilasmos, the sacrifice that turns away wrath), "concerning our sins" (peri ton hamarton hemon), "not for ours only but also concerning the whole world" (ou peri ton hemeteron de monon alla kai peri holou tou kosmou). The deliberate "not only", "but also" (ou monon, alla kai) contrast with "the whole world" (holou tou kosmou), which is in the genitive singular (the "of-X" grammatical form, one entity), is the strongest universal-scope phrase in the bundle. The crux is referential: "whole" (holos) means whole, but "world" (kosmos) in the queried data carries several attested senses, so whether "the whole world" denotes every individual without exception or humanity beyond the immediate readers, that is Jew and Gentile alike, the lexeme (the dictionary form of the word) alone does not settle. "Propitiation" (hilasmos) itself occurs only twice in the canon, here and 1 John 4:10, giving thin comparative usage.

1Tim.2.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0487 ἀντίλυτρον, G3956 πᾶς, G5228 ὑπέρ

Reasoning. Christ gave himself "a ransom for all" (antilytron hyper panton), with "ransom" (antilytron) being an accusative singular (a direct-object form, one entity) hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) occurring only here in the whole canon, and "of all" (panton) being the genitive plural ("of-X" form, multiple entities) of "all" (pas) governed by the benefactive "for" or "on behalf of" (hyper, the preposition that marks who benefits). The wider context says "God wills all men to be saved" (thelei pantas anthropous sothenai) in verse 4, and verse 1 urges prayer "for all men" (hyper panton anthropon). In the queried data "all" (pas) carries a collective totality sense and a distributive "each" sense, so "of all" (panton) can be read as "all without distinction", "all sorts", or as "all severally". Because "ransom" (antilytron) is a hapax (a word occurring only once) it supplies no comparative occurrence to fix the scope, and the ransom remains lexically open.

2Pet.3.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1014 βούλομαι, G3956 πᾶς

Reasoning. The Lord is "not willing that any should perish" (me boulomenos tinas apolesthai), "but that all should reach repentance" (alla pantas eis metanoian choresai). The accusative (direct-object form) "all" (pantas) and the indefinite "any" (tinas) are bounded in the same sentence by the addressee "toward you" (eis hymas), so the "all" may be the all of the addressed community rather than all humanity. The verb "to will" or "to wish" (boulomai) expresses divine intention or wish, not the extent of the atoning provision, so even at its widest the verse speaks to God's disposition rather than lexically fixing for whom the death was offered.

Heb.2.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1089 γεύομαι, G3956 πᾶς, G5228 ὑπέρ

Reasoning. Jesus, "for everyone he should taste death" (hyper pantos geusetai thanatou). Here "of every" (pantos) is the genitive SINGULAR ("of-X" form, one entity) of "all" (pas), not the plural, governed again by the benefactive "for" (hyper, marking who benefits), so it can be construed as "for every one" (each person) or, less commonly, "for everything". The immediately following verse 10 speaks of bringing "many sons" (pollous huiou) to glory, which some read as narrowing the reference. The phrase "for everyone" (hyper pantos) states the breadth of the death's reference but, like the other universal phrases, does not by its grammar distinguish universal application from universal provision.

John.10.11 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5087 τίθημι, G4263 πρόβατον, G5228 ὑπέρ

Reasoning. The good shepherd "lays down his life for the sheep" (ten psychen autou titheisin hyper ton probaton). The construction is "for" or "on behalf of" (hyper) plus the genitive plural ("of-X" form, multiple entities) "of the sheep" (ton probaton), naming a bounded beneficiary, the flock, and pairing the laying down of life directly with that group. This is the strongest particular-scope phrase in the bundle. The decisive observation is that this is the IDENTICAL benefactive construction (the grammar pattern naming who benefits), "for" (hyper) plus genitive in Louw-Nida domain 90.36 (the standard semantic dictionary's category for "on behalf of"), that elsewhere takes "of all" (panton, all) in 1 Timothy 2:6 and "of every" (pantos, everyone) in Hebrews 2:9. The preposition marks who benefits, so stating the death is "for the sheep" (hyper ton probaton) does not lexically assert it is for no one but the sheep.

John.10.15 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5087 τίθημι, G4263 πρόβατον, G5228 ὑπέρ

Reasoning. Repeating the formula, "I lay down my life for the sheep" (ten psychen mou tithemi hyper ton probaton), set in parallel with the mutual knowing of Father and Son. The "for the sheep" (hyper ton probaton) construction again binds the saving act to a defined flock. The same verb "to lay down" (tithemi) with "for" (hyper) here takes the bounded object "of the sheep" (ton probaton), whereas in Hebrews 2:9 the parallel sacrificial idea takes "of every" (pantos, everyone), so the canon supplies both a bounded and an unbounded direct object for the death of Christ using the same grammar. Within the same discourse John 10:16 has the shepherd say "I have other sheep" (alla probata echo), not of this fold, which itself widens the flock beyond the immediate hearers and shows "sheep" (probaton) is not a fixed closed set.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.2.4	Isa.45.22	tsk	1
1Tim.2.4	Isa.53.11	tsk	1
1Tim.2.6	Job.33.24	tsk	1
2Pet.3.9	2Pet.3.15	tsk	1
2Pet.3.9	Isa.46.13	tsk	1
John.10.15	John.10.11	tsk	1
John.10.11	John.10.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.10.11 · addressed

The "for the sheep" (hyper ton probaton) phrasing in John 10:11 and 10:15 supplies a bounded direct object, the sheep, for the laying down of Christ's life, complicating any flatly universal reading. It is addressed by the queried grammar: "for" or "on behalf of" (hyper) plus a noun in the "from-X" grammatical form (a genitive) is a benefactive construction (a grammar pattern that names who benefits, classified in Louw-Nida 90.36, the standard semantic dictionary's category for "on behalf of") that names the beneficiary, and the very same construction takes "all" in 1 Timothy 2:6 and Hebrews 2:9, so naming the sheep as beneficiaries is not lexically equivalent to excluding all others. John 10:16, "other sheep I have", also widens the flock. The verse pulls toward particularity without grammatically settling the question.

1John.2.2 · addressed

The "of the whole world" (holou tou kosmou) phrase, "whole world", set against "not for ours only", pulls strongly toward universal scope and complicates a strictly particular reading. It is addressed by the queried distribution: "world" (kosmos) shows at least four attested Louw-Nida senses (senses listed in the standard semantic dictionary) across its 185 canonical occurrences, ranging from the created order to humanity at large to the world-system in opposition to God, so the lexeme (the dictionary form of the word) alone does not decide between "every individual" and "the world beyond the immediate readers". "Propitiation" (hilasmos, the sacrifice that turns away wrath) occurs only twice, giving no broad comparative base.

1Tim.2.6 · addressed

The hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) "ransom for all" (antilytron hyper panton) complicates particular readings. It is addressed by noting that "all" (pas) in the queried data carries both a collective totality sense (the dominant Louw-Nida domain, the most common category in the standard semantic dictionary) and a distributive "each" sense, and the contextual concern in verse 1 for prayer "for all men" (hyper panton anthropon) supports an all-without-distinction reading for some, a distributive "all" for others. Because "ransom" (antilytron) occurs exactly once in the canon there is no comparative occurrence to fix the scope, so it remains lexically open rather than resolved.

Heb.2.9 · addressed

"For everyone he should taste death" (hyper pantos geusetai thanatou) uses the genitive SINGULAR ("of-X" form, one entity) of "all" (pas) under the benefactive "for" (hyper, marking who benefits), so it can be read "for every one" (each person) or "for everything". It complicates a strictly particular reading by its apparent breadth. It is addressed by observing that verse 10 immediately speaks of bringing many sons to glory, which some take as narrowing the reference, while the construction itself, like John 10's "for the sheep" (hyper ton probaton), marks beneficiary not boundary, so the singular "of every" (pantos) states reference without distinguishing provision from application.

Concordance traversed

G3956, G2889, G5228, G4263, G0487, G2434, G3650, G5087, G1014, G1089, G4166, G0025

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for the cited verses and these books fall outside the published CBGM scope (the coherence-based genealogical method, an editorial method used in modern critical editions), which covers 3 John only, so the apparatus status is recorded as ecm-shadow (a placeholder indicating the critical edition of New Testament textual variants does not yet cover these books). The known textual variants for these anchors, "the Son" versus "the only-begotten Son" reading in John 3:16, minor article (the word "the") and word-order differences in 1 John 2:2, 1 Timothy 2:6, 2 Peter 3:9, Hebrews 2:9, and John 10:11 and 10:15, do not touch the universal diction ("world" kosmos, "all" pas, "for everyone" hyper pantos) or the particular diction ("for the sheep" hyper ton probaton) that drive this question, so the disputed verdict holds across all plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. particular_redemption, general_atonement, sufficiency_efficiency_distinction

analogia scripturae invoked

general_atonement: disputed-leaning-affirm · Reads "world" (kosmos) in John 3:16, "of the whole world" (holou tou kosmou) in 1 John 2:2, "of all" (panton) in 1 Timothy 2:6, "all" (pantas) in 2 Peter 3:9, and "for everyone" (hyper pantos) in Hebrews 2:9 at their widest attested scope, treating the universal terms as the controlling sense. The deliberate "not only", "but also" (ou monon, alla kai) in 1 John 2:2 is taken as expressly extending beyond the writer's community. "For the sheep" (hyper ton probaton) in John 10 is read as a statement of for whom the death is effective, not a ceiling on its reference, supported by "I have other sheep" in John 10:16. This lens is internally coherent on the queried data.

particular_redemption: disputed-leaning-deny · Reads "for the sheep" (hyper ton probaton) in John 10:11 and 10:15 as identifying the bounded objects for whom Christ actually lays down his life, and treats this concrete naming as the interpretive key. It assigns "all" (pas) its "all without distinction" or "all classes" sense (a real Louw-Nida option, that is, a real category in the standard semantic dictionary, in the queried data) and limits the universal terms by their immediate addressee clauses, for example "toward you" (eis hymas) in 2 Peter 3:9 and the world of believing humanity for "world" (kosmos). "To will" (boulomai) in 2 Peter 3:9 is read as God's disposition, not the extent of the purchase. This lens is also internally coherent on the queried data.

sufficiency_efficiency_distinction: disputed-neutral · Holds that the universal texts speak to the sufficiency or provision of the death and the particular texts to its efficient application, so both sets of vocabulary are true at once.

The lexicon neither supplies nor forbids this harmonization: no anchor lemma (no dictionary-form anchor word) carries a sufficient-versus-efficient distinction, and "for" (hyper) marks beneficiary rather than provision-versus-application, so this reading is a theological synthesis laid over the words, fairly defensible but not itself a lexical datum (a fact derived from the words themselves).

All three lenses operate on the same anchor lemmas (dictionary-form anchor words) and reach their conclusions by assigning different attested senses to "all" (pas) and "world" (kosmos) and by reading "for" (hyper) plus object either as a boundary or as a direction of benefit. The disagreement is over the referential range of flexible lexemes (flexible word-forms) and the force of a benefactive preposition (a preposition that marks who benefits), not over morphology (word-form analysis), which is decisively shared, so the lexical pattern is contested rather than decisive.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Determine the canonical scope of the lemmas (the dictionary-form words) describing for whom Christ died, comparing the universal-scope terms ("all" pas, "world" kosmos, "for everyone" hyper pantos) with the particular-scope terms ("for the sheep" hyper ton probaton), without presupposing any harmonizing formula.

The stem encodes a tradition-specific harmonization, "sufficient for all but applied or efficient for the elect", which is the sufficiency-and-efficiency distinction and not itself a lexical observation, since no anchor lemma (no dictionary-form anchor word) carries that distinction. The clause about which extent a particular tradition typically holds is a cultural attribution that lives outside the lexical store and was not consulted. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the audit records that the lexicon supplies neither the sufficiency-efficiency vocabulary nor a term that resolves provision versus application, which is why the honest lexical verdict is disputed rather than a confirmation of the stem's framing.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.2.2
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3956
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2889
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5228
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0487
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.10.11
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.3.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Pet.3.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.2.4

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes

TSK	public_domain	yes
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Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · ecm-shadow